MCCJ 527 · ORGANIZED CRIME AND CORRUPTION

Follow the Bullet

War Dogs (2016) and the grey arms trade, one stop at a time

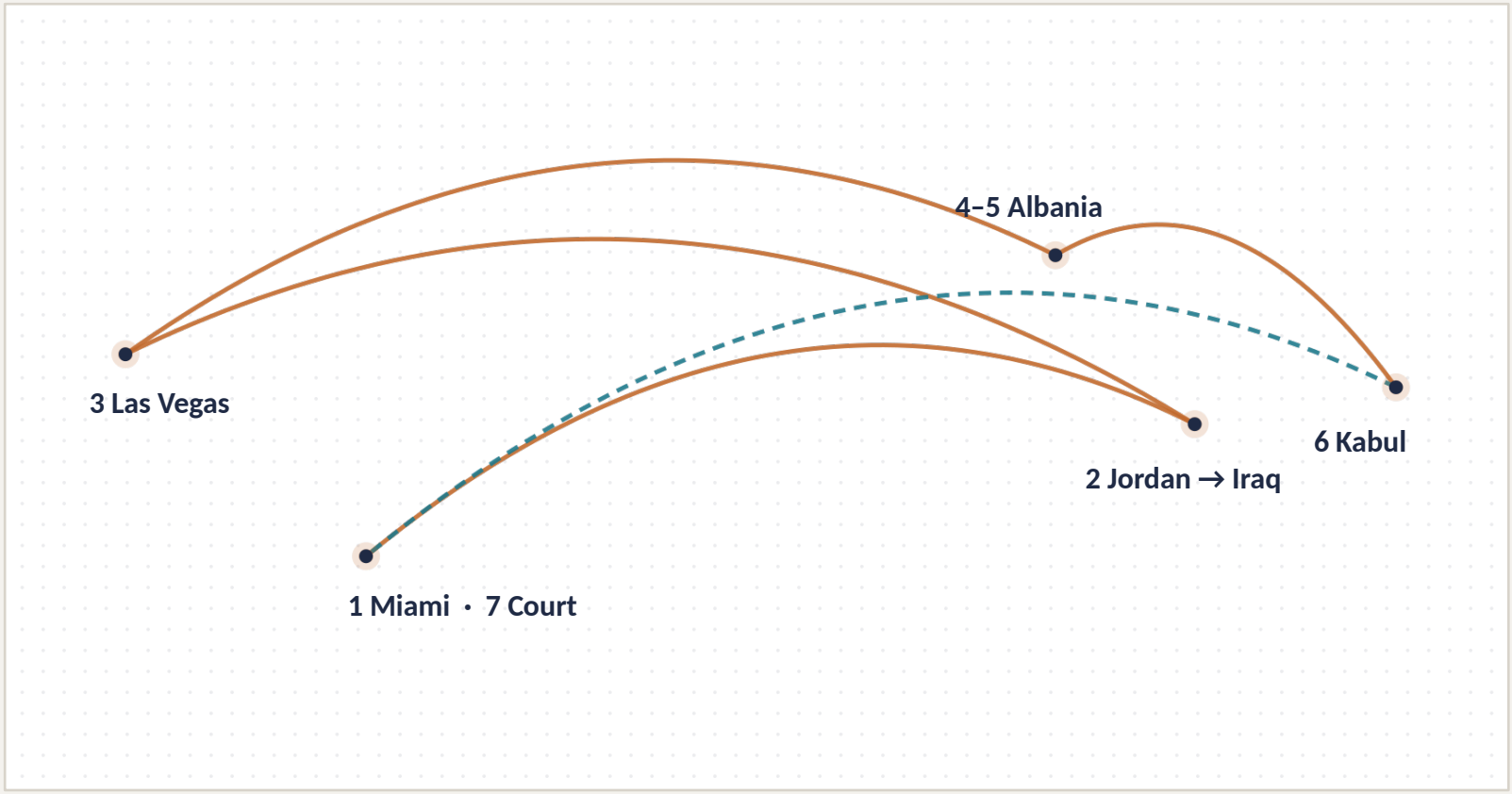


GROUP 6

Roll 27 · Roll 8 · Roll 37 · Roll 33 · Roll 24 · Roll 21

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Five countries, two young men, one $298M contract



THE FILM

War Dogs (2016)

Dir. Todd Phillips · Warner Bros.

CAST

Jonah Hill (Efraim), Miles Teller (David), Ana de Armas, Bradley Cooper

GENRE · SOURCE

Crime comedy-drama based on Guy Lawson's reporting (2011, 2015)

THEME

Profiting from war without fighting it

Copper line: the bullet's journey. Dashed teal line: the money returning to Miami. Map is schematic.

Stop 1: demand meets desperation in Miami

Miami Beach, Florida

The starting point

WHAT HAPPENS HERE

David, a broke massage therapist with a baby on the way, reunites with childhood friend Efraim. Efraim's company, AEY, bids online for the "crumbs" of Pentagon procurement: small contracts the big defence firms ignore.

THE BULLET
Not yet bought

THE MONEY
Pentagon posts tenders online

CRIMINOLOGY CHECKPOINT

Strain and institutional anomie

Merton (1938); Messner & Rosenfeld (1994)

David accepts the goal of wealth but lacks legitimate means, so he "innovates". Money starts to override family.

Differential association

Sutherland (1940)

David learns the techniques and the justifications of the trade from Efraim, his close friend.

Stop 2: a grey run through Jordan into Iraq

Amman, Jordan → Iraq

The first big risk

WHAT HAPPENS HERE

A shipment of pistols for the Iraqi police is stuck in Jordan. Instead of losing the contract, the pair fly to Amman, rely on local fixers and drive the cargo through dangerous territory into Iraq. They get paid, and bigger contracts follow.

THE BULLET
Pistols stuck at the border

THE MONEY
Fixers paid to move the cargo

CRIMINOLOGY CHECKPOINT

Enterprise model

Smith (1980)

Legal and illegal business sit on one spectrum. Here AEY slides from legal bidding into grey dealing to keep a contract.

Rational choice

Cornish & Clarke (1986)

A calculated gamble: high reward, risks they judge worth taking. Success rewards the next, bigger risk.

Stop 3: the broker who cannot trade in his own name

Las Vegas, Nevada

At an arms fair

WHAT HAPPENS HERE

The pair meet Henry Girard, an arms dealer on a terrorist watch list who cannot sell to the US directly. He has access to about 100 million rounds in Albania. AEY needs supply; Henry needs a clean American front. A deal is born.

THE BULLET
Located: ~100M rounds in Albania

THE MONEY
Henry wants his cut

Henry Girard is a composite character inspired by the real broker Heinrich Thomet.

CRIMINOLOGY CHECKPOINT

Network model and brokerage

Morselli (2009)

Power belongs to brokers who connect worlds that cannot reach each other: the Pentagon on one side, Balkan stockpiles on the other.

Patron–client and crime–terror nexus

Albini (1971)

Henry trades access for a share of profits. A watch-listed actor stays in the market by borrowing a clean company's name.

Stop 4: an Albanian stockpile and a chain of hands

Tirana, Albania

The source of supply

WHAT HAPPENS HERE

The ammunition sits in old state depots. To reach it, AEY works through local intermediaries and officials, each of whom takes a share. Pressure grows as Efraim tries to cut Henry out of the profits.

THE BULLET
Old stock in state depots

THE MONEY
Officials and middlemen skim

CRIMINOLOGY CHECKPOINT

Corruption
Transparency International (n.d.)

The abuse of entrusted power for private gain: officials and intermediaries profit from controlling access to state stock.

Klitgaard's formula: C = M + D – A
Klitgaard (1988)

Monopoly (Henry's access) plus discretion (officials, fixers) minus accountability (weak wartime oversight) equals corruption.

Not in the film: Albania's Gërdec depot explosion of March 2008 killed 26 people and led to charges against senior officials (Al Jazeera, 2008).

Stop 5: the repack that turned a deal into a fraud

Albania, a warehouse

The point of no return

WHAT HAPPENS HERE

David discovers the ammunition was made in China, which is banned under a US arms embargo and by the contract itself. Instead of disclosing it, AEY has the rounds repackaged to remove the Chinese markings and passes them off as Albanian.

THE BULLET
"Made in China" markings removed

THE MONEY
$298M contract at stake

Repackaging is documented in the real case (Lawson, 2015). Quoted excuses are our paraphrases.

CRIMINOLOGY CHECKPOINT

White-collar crime and fraud

Sutherland (1940)

Respectable businessmen commit crime in the course of their work: deceiving the government to protect a contract.

Techniques of neutralization

Sykes & Matza (1957)

Excuses such as "the troops still get working bullets" (denial of injury) and "the government does it too" silence their conscience.

Stop 6: Kabul, where the bullets and the victims meet

Kabul, Afghanistan

The end user

WHAT HAPPENS HERE

The decades-old ammunition is delivered to the Afghan National Army. The victims are not on screen for long: soldiers relying on old rounds, and taxpayers who funded the contract. So is the group behind it “organized crime”?

THE BULLET
Decades-old rounds issued to soldiers

THE MONEY
US taxpayers pay the bill

CRIMINOLOGY CHECKPOINT

UNTOC definition: yes, organized crime

UNODC (2004), Article 2

A structured group of 3+ persons (Efraim, David, financier, Henry, suppliers), existing over time, committing serious crime for material benefit.

Transnational organized crime

UNODC (2004)

The scheme crossed the US, Jordan, Iraq, Albania and Afghanistan, exploiting gaps between national laws and weak record-keeping.

Stop 7: a Miami courtroom, and why AEY is not the mafia

Federal court, Miami

The end of the line

WHAT HAPPENS HERE

Greed and betrayal destroy the partnership, journalists expose AEY, and the government investigates. In the film, as in reality, Efraim is sentenced to 4 years in prison and David, who cooperates, to 7 months of house arrest.

THE BULLET
AEY's supplies exposed (2008)

THE MONEY
Profits lost; prison and house arrest

Sentences: Lawson (2015).

CRIMINOLOGY CHECKPOINT

Abadinsky's attributes: mostly not met

Abadinsky (2013)

No hierarchy, no exclusive membership, no code, and it collapsed once its leaders were charged. It is not the mafia.

Our classification

Sutherland (1940); Kramer et al. (2002)

Organized white-collar crime, made possible by state-corporate failure: war outsourced to the lowest bidder with weak vetting.

Which model explains the whole journey? Enterprise and network

Enterprise Smith (1980)	●●●●● Strong fit	Stops 1–5: AEY slides from legal bidding to fixers to fraud as demand grows.
Network Morselli (2009)	●●●●● Strong fit	Stops 3–4: brokers bridging the Pentagon and Balkan stockpiles hold the power.
Patron–client Albini (1971)	●●●○○ Partial fit	Stop 3: Henry trades access to supply for a share of the profits.
Hierarchical Cressey (1969)	●○○○○ Weak fit	Stop 7: no ranks, no code, no family; the group collapses after arrests.

Fit ratings are the group's assessment.

Accurate in substance, exaggerated in style

WHAT IT GETS RIGHT

- Breaks the mafia stereotype: crime as a business with invoices
- Fits the UN definition and the enterprise and network models
- Offenders who never see themselves as criminals
- Real facts: the $298M contract, the repack, the sentences

WHAT IT GETS WRONG

- Comedy glamorizes the money and softens the fraud
- Henry is a composite; the Albanian threats are invented
- Blames two young men, not the system that let them in
- Leaves out real victims, including the 26 killed at Gërdec

Sources: Lawson (2015); Al Jazeera (2008). Verdict is the group's assessment.

END OF THE LINE

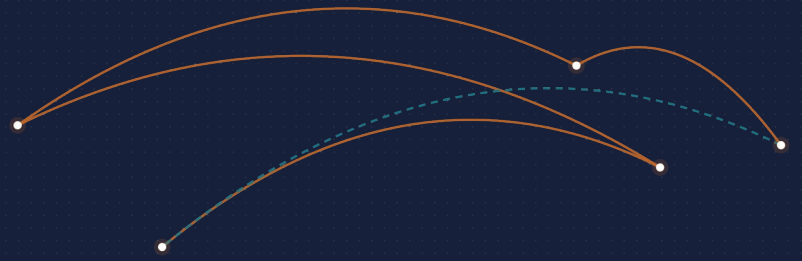
Follow the bullet and you find a business. Follow the money and you find the system.

THE ANSWER

Organized crime under the UN definition, but not the mafia: organized white-collar crime.

THE LESSON FOR BANGLADESH

Large procurement relies on middlemen too. Vet contractors, disclose real owners, and check where goods come from.



Thank you. *Questions?*